

23 August 1939

NAZI-SOVIET NON-AGGRESSION PACT

An unexpected agreement between the two hostile powers allowed each – at least temporarily – to build up its forces without fear of attack. A secret protocol attached to the treaty defined respective spheres of influence in Poland, the Baltic states, and Finland.



△ Signing of the pact



1889-1945
ADOLF HITLER

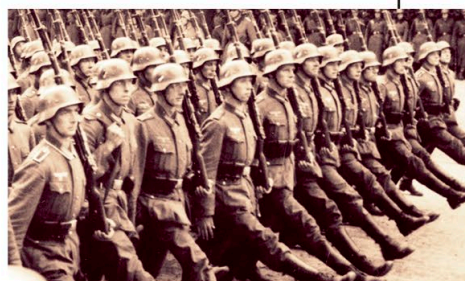
After joining the Nazi party in 1919 and pressing for national revolution, Hitler became Chancellor of Germany in 1933. As effective dictator, he pursued a racist agenda and drew the world into war.

1939

September 1939 US President Roosevelt opts for US neutrality in the war while favouring the Allied powers

30 November 1939 The Winter War breaks out when Soviet troops invade neutral Finland

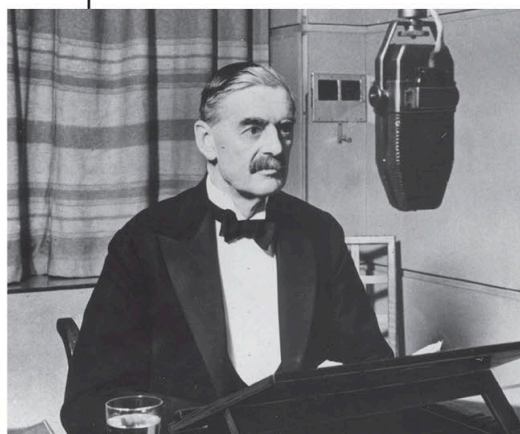
▽ German troops in Warsaw



1 September 1939

GERMAN INVASION OF POLAND

Citing invented provocations, Hitler sent troops into Poland on several fronts, driving the defending forces eastward. Sixteen days later, Soviet forces joined the assault by attacking Poland from the east, catching the defenders in a pincer movement. By early October, formal resistance was overcome and the previously free nation was divided up between the aggressors as agreed in the secret protocol of the Nazi-Soviet Pact.



△ Neville Chamberlain addresses the nation

3 September 1939

DECLARATION OF WAR ON GERMANY

The German invasion of Poland discredited the policy of appeasement by which British and French leaders had hoped to guarantee "peace in our time". British Prime Minister Neville Chamberlain and French premier Édouard Daladier issued an ultimatum that if German troops were not immediately withdrawn, war would be declared. When Hitler's forces instead pressed on with their conquest, the declaration was duly made and World War II began.